

Small Talk is Great [C1]

Alla macchinetta del caffè o con il passeggero che ci è seduto accanto in aereo: una chiacchiera, seppur superficiale, aiuta a creare un'intesa.



People love to [complain](#) about [small talk](#). Some say it's "painful", "dishonest" and "a [chore](#)." Some of my own friends have called it "boring" and "exhausting." A

2016 Wired magazine article titled “Small talk should be [banned](#)” argued that [idle chit-chat](#) “does not build relationships and does not make us happier”, but persists because “we actively seek the lowest common denominator.” Instead, the authors suggest deeper conversation topics, such as: “What is your relationship with God?” or “What is something you fear in life?” I’m here to say, respectfully: all of this is wrong. First, I find the anti-[small talk](#) position arrogant, marked by a sense that the [holder](#) is more [thoughtfully](#) and deeply [engaged](#) with life than everyone else. When I was in [middle school](#), I knew a kid who only listened to inaccessible goth rock and [dismissed](#) anyone who listened to the Top 40 as [shallow](#) and stupid. That’s how [small talk](#) haters sound to me: “You want to talk about the weather? Uh, ever heard of mortality?!” Sure, [small talk](#) sucks sometimes. I once got trapped talking to someone for thirty minutes about [pencil lead](#). But you can’t always expect everyone to meet you in the [mucky](#) depths of human existence. Maybe the person you’re talking to had a long day and still has to go home and make dinner and put their kids to sleep. You’re going to demand they reflect on what happens after we die? Everyone’s just trying to [get through the day](#). “I find [small talk](#) incredibly useful,” says Lizzie Post, co-president of the Emily Post Institute, which provides etiquette advice and training. She describes [small talk](#) as a “safety zone” for people to be in together. Religion, sex and politics are all excellent conversation topics, she says, but they may not feel accessible or comfortable to everyone all the time. Chatting about last night’s football game, the food at an event or someone’s hobbies is a much easier way to build initial [rapport](#). Then, if the other person seems open, you can [dip your toe](#) into deeper topics. A couple of years ago, for example, a man in his late sixties sat next to me on a plane and we started chatting. We said hello and exchanged [niceties](#) about the weather (hot) and why we were travelling (to see family.) We talked about work and recent vacations, and by the end of the two-hour flight, I knew all about his various [career pivots](#), and how psilocybin had transformed his life and saved his marriage. Interesting! But we only got there because we started with [small talk](#). Had I opened with, “What is your experience with psychedelics and how have they affected your relationships?” that might have been [off-putting](#).

Language

Could the English Language Die? Al giorno d’oggi sembra impossibile da immaginare, ma potrebbero esserci le condizioni perché un giorno l’inglese possa morire, come è successo al latino. Daniel Francis Post suspects some people don’t like [small talk](#) because it doesn’t always allow them to be the star of the show — if you ask someone about their hobbies, then you have to listen to what they say. This can be challenging for those who prefer to be the talker. “Some people want to be seen in a certain way, and don’t feel like [small talk](#) gets them to be seen in that interesting way,” she says. And if you think [small talk](#) is boring, that may be a skill issue. It requires a real [back-and-forth](#), even if it doesn’t [plumb](#) the depths of someone’s soul. Listening attentively can significantly improve the quality of your [chit-chat](#), Post says. “Have your radar up,” she explains. “Pay attention to whether

the other person seems interested, and if they've contributed anything to the conversation. If you've been talking for a long time and the other person hasn't said anything on the topic, they're probably bored. Maybe their eyes [have glazed over](#) a little bit," Post says. "I would take it as a sign to change the topic, and ask them something about themselves." She suggests a question like: "What's keeping you interested these days?" Yes, [small talk](#) can be [shallow](#). But consider this: sitting in a [kiddie pool](#) and [sunning yourself](#) while [sipping](#) a soda is far more relaxing than [shivering](#) in the open ocean. Shallow can be [delightful](#). So [go forth](#), and [gab](#) about public transit and a new restaurant you heard was pretty good. But if someone brings up [pencil lead](#), just pretend you have to take a phone call. Published in The Guardian on 21 November 2025. Reprinted with permission.

Glossary

- **middle school** = scuola media
- **career pivots** = cambi di carriera
- **shivering** = rabbrivire
- **rapport** = intesa, sintonia
- **complain** = lamentarsi
- **thoughtfully** = sapientemente, in modo riflessivo
- **shallow** = superficiale
- **mucky** = sudicie
- **get through the day** = arrivare a fine giornata
- **dip your toe** = tastare il terreno
- **sunning yourself** = prendere il sole
- **small talk** = chiacchiere, parlare del più e del meno
- **banned** = vietare
- **dismissed** = ignorare, respingere
- **plumb** = scandagliare
- **sipping** = sorseggiare
- **chit-chat** = chiacchierata
- **niceties** = convenevoli, carinerie
- **off-putting** = sgradevole
- **kiddie pool** = piscina per bambini
- **delightful** = delizioso
- **idle** = inutile
- **holder** = sostenitore
- **pencil lead** = mina della matita
- **have glazed over** = offuscare
- **back-and-forth** = botta e risposta
- **go forth** = andare avanti, procedere
- **chore** = seccatura, incombenza
- **engaged** = impegnato
- **gab** = chiacchierare